What's it worth?

Forms of currency were developed in the ancient world to replace the awkward system of bartering, which was dependent on the person you wished to trade with needing something that you had to offer in return. But these currencies were not money as we know it today. Instead, they used commodities that were necessary or useful, such as sacks of corn or barley, as a medium of exchange. This "commodity money" could be used to buy all kinds of different goods, which were priced in terms of a certain weight of grain. It wasn't only food that was considered to have worth, though. Many societies prized precious stones and metals, or even seashells, and these too were used as currency. One advantage of using these was that, in addition to being recognized as valuable, they don't deteriorate over time and are more convenient as a currency than large quantities of grain. In the ancient civilizations of the Mediterranean and Middle East, gold and silver became the primary medium of exchange, and goods changed hands for a set weight of these precious metals.

> GOLD STILL REPRESENTS THE ULTIMATE FORM OF PAYMENT IN THE WORLD.
>
> ALAN GREENSPAN, FORMER CHAIR OF THE US FEDERAL RESERVE

Coins and banknotes

For convenience, people began to produce pieces of these metals in specific weights, often in the form of small disks that were easy to carry. To make life easier, the weight of the metal was stamped on each piece, making them the first recognizable coins. As the use of these coins spread, they were stamped with a mark of authority, such as the head of the country's ruler, to show that